

Economist specializing in causal inference, predictive modeling and computation, especially in big data settings. Most of my time these days is spent thinking about AI—measuring its impact and identifying opportunities where it can bring durable, long-term value. In my spare time, I maintain and contribute to a variety of open-source projects.

Experience **Amazon.com** 2022–Present

Principal Economist, Stores Ads Science

- Developed econometric and ML models to measure the causal impact of interventions on seller, advertiser, and marketplace outcomes, informing \$100M business operations and strategic decisions
- Built and deployed analytical tools and workflows for large-scale causal measurement and AI evaluation in production settings
- Authored technical and strategic documents and presented findings to senior leadership (VP+)

University of Oregon 2017–2022

Assistant Professor, Department of Economics

- Independent research, teaching and media engagement

University of California Santa Barbara 2015–2017

Postdoctoral Scholar, Bren School of Environmental Science & Management

- Independent research

Affiliations **University of Oregon** 2023–Present

Courtesy Assistant Professor of Economics

Education

Ph.D., Economics, Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)	2015
M.Sc., Economics & Business Administration, NHH	2011
M.Sc., International Management, CEMS	2011
B.Com. (Hons), Economics, University of Cape Town (UCT)	2005
B.Bus.Sc., Marketing, UCT	2004

Research **SELECTED PUBLICATIONS**

1. G.R. McDermott (2021). “[Skeptic priors and climate consensus](#).” *Climatic Change*, 166 (1), 1–23.
2. G.R. McDermott, K.C. Meng, G.G. McDonald, & C.J. Costello (2019). “[The blue paradox: Preemptive overfishing in marine reserves](#).” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 116 (12), 5319–5325.
3. M.G. Burgess, G.R. McDermott, et al. (2018). “[Protecting marine mammals, turtles and birds by rebuilding global fisheries](#).” *Science*, 359(6381), 1255–1258.
4. G.R. McDermott & Ø.A. Nilsen (2014). “[Electricity Prices, River Temperatures and Cooling Water Scarcity](#).” *Land Economics*, 90(1), 131–148.

SELECTED WORKING PAPERS

1. R. Molina, J.C. Villaseñor-Derbez, G.G. McDonald, & G.R. McDermott. "[The Economic and Environmental Cost of Pirate Avoidance](#)." *CESifo Working Paper No. 11077*. *R&R Nature Communications*.
2. L.R. Bergé, K. Butts, & G.R. McDermott. "[Fast and user-friendly econometrics estimations: the R package fixest](#)". *Under review*.
3. G.R. McDermott & B.H. Hansen. "[Labor reallocation and remote work during COVID-19: Real-time evidence from GitHub](#)." *NBER Working Paper no. w29598*.
4. C.J. Costello, M. DeLara, G.R. McDermott, & M.B. Ward. "AI Search." *Draft available soon*.

Code

Software:

- [dbreg](#). Fast regressions on database backends.
- [etwfe](#). Extended twoway fixed-effects.
- [ritest](#). Fast randomization inference.
- [tinypplot](#). Lightweight visualization library.
- ... and more at github.com/grantmcdermott (+3k stars)

Languages: R, Python, SQL, Julia, Stata

Frameworks: AWS, GCP, Spark, Unix

Teaching

WORKSHOPS

(Pretty) big data wrangling with DuckDB and Polars, Banco de Portugal, Dec 2025.

Data Science Fundamentals, ZEW, Aug 2021.

COURSES

EC 607: [Data Science for Economists](#) (Ph.D.)

EC 510: [Big Data in Economics](#) (M.Sc.)

EC 434: [Environmental Economics](#) (Undergraduate)

EC 310: [Intermediate Microeconomic Theory](#) (Undergraduate)

Service

Journal referee *Energy Economics*; *Energy Policy*; *Land Economics*; *Journal of Econometrics*; *Journal of Environmental Economics & Management*; *Marine Policy*; *Natural Resource Modeling*; *Nature Sustainability*; *Scandinavian Journal of Economics*; *Water Resources Research*

Software CRAN Econometrics Task View (cran.r-project.org/view=Econometrics)

Conferences The Workshop in Environmental Economics and Data Science (tweeds.io)

Other

NKC Independent Economists, <i>Economist</i> , Cape Town, South Africa	2009
Millennium Cycle For Change, <i>Expedition member</i> , Cairo to Cape Town	2008
IBM, <i>Field Sales Executive</i> , Portsmouth, United Kingdom	2007
SALDRU, <i>Researcher</i> , Cape Town, South Africa	2006

Personal

Citizenship: South Africa and United States (dual).